

Fractured Whodunits, Reconstructed Selves: Computational Narratives of Hercule Poirot Across Page and Screen

This study explores how cinematic adaptations of Agatha Christie's *Hercule Poirot* novels, directed by Kenneth Branagh, reconfigure not only narrative structure but also the emotional and social systems embedded within them. Drawing on a comparative corpus of three novels—*Murder on the Orient Express*, *Death on the Nile*, and *Hallowe'en Party*—and their respective film adaptations, the paper applies computational methods including sentiment arc analysis, character network modeling, and a custom-built Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI). The findings illuminate how Branagh's adaptations strategically humanize Poirot, elevate secondary characters, and shift genre logics—from logical deduction to psychological horror. Through dynamic visual and structural transformations, the adaptations emerge not as retellings but as narrative reauthorings that mirror contemporary affective aesthetics and social anxieties. By merging digital humanities tools with adaptation theory, this study reframes adaptation as a creative act of emotional and structural translation, expanding the analytical repertoire of both literary and filmic scholarship.

Keywords: Narrative Adaptation Digital Humanities Character Network Analysis Sentiment Modeling Hercule Poirot

1. The Detective Who Won't Stay Still

Hercule Poirot has always been more than a detective. He is a vessel—of logic, of eccentricity, of cultural projection. Since his first appearance in 1920, Agatha Christie's meticulous Belgian sleuth has migrated across decades, continents, and media formats, collecting not only corpses but also new interpretations along the way. Today, he is simultaneously a literary figure, a cinematic icon, and a computational subject. He is played by different actors, but more importantly, he is played differently—at times a comic figure of fussiness, at others a haunted conduit for moral ambiguity. This protean quality, far from diluting his identity, defines it.

This study explores how Poirot is reconfigured—emotionally, structurally, and narratively—in recent cinematic adaptations directed by Kenneth Branagh. The adaptations of *Murder on the Orient Express* (2017), *Death on the Nile* (2022), and *A Haunting in Venice* (2023) offer fertile terrain for studying adaptation not as repetition, but as revision. Across these films, Poirot is transformed from a surgical logician into a psychologically conflicted, emotionally porous character. The surrounding characters, too, are reshuffled—some elevated in prominence, others flattened, erased, or rewritten. Even genre is unstable: the classical whodunit becomes, by the third installment, an atmospheric psychological horror.

Yet beyond thematic or visual changes lies something more structural and measurable. This study leverages computational methods to trace how Branagh's adaptations alter the emotional infrastructure and social geometry of Christie's novels. Using sentiment arc modeling, character network analysis, and a new Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI), we map not only what changes, but how those changes unfold across narrative time. Do certain characters become more central in the adaptation than in the source novel? How do emotional arcs steepen or flatten? Where do communities dissolve, coalesce, or fracture?

These questions are not only literary but methodological. By merging digital humanities tools with contemporary adaptation theory, this paper intervenes in two critical domains: first, in the evolving scholarship that sees adaptation as creative reconfiguration rather than fidelity-based translation;

second, in the computational turn that seeks to visualize and quantify patterns that elude the naked eye.

Ultimately, Poirot's refusal to stay still—across formats, genres, and decades—mirrors the broader dynamics of adaptation itself. What this paper uncovers is not just the evolution of a character, but the reprogramming of a storyworld, in which emotion, structure, and sociality are algorithmically reshaped for a new medium, and a new audience.

2. From Blueprints to Blue Notes: Why Fidelity Isn't Enough

Once the cornerstone of adaptation discourse, fidelity has become its ghost. For decades, scholars weighed adaptations against their literary “blueprints,” parsing whether plot points had been preserved, character traits retained, and endings mirrored. The underlying assumption was that a good adaptation stayed close to its source—as if the task of cinema were to mimic literature with visual precision. This fidelity paradigm, as Linda Hutcheon (2022) and Thomas Leitch (2022) have argued, is no longer tenable. Adaptation is not blueprint-following. It is jazz.

Recent theorists have turned toward understanding adaptation as a process of interpretive transformation. Robert Stam (2020) reframes adaptation as dialogic rather than derivative, a conversation across media shaped by aesthetic, cultural, and technological contingencies. Branagh's Hercule Poirot films exemplify this shift. These works do not aim to replicate Christie's plotting; they recalibrate her tonal palette, reassign narrative focus, and in the case of *A Haunting in Venice*, recompose the genre altogether. The goal is not faithfulness, but resonance.

This turn from blueprint to blue note aligns with broader developments in media studies, which recognize adaptations as situated cultural objects—produced within specific commercial, political, and emotional ecologies. Christina Flynn (2023) argues that post-truth sensibilities have increased the demand for emotionally resonant, affect-driven storytelling, which often departs from canonical narrative structures. In this climate, adaptations are judged not by their proximity to the source, but by their capacity to evoke new meaning.

Branagh's adaptations use the figure of Poirot as both anchor and tuning fork. While the character remains central, he is increasingly reframed—less as an omniscient detective and more as an emotionally burdened man haunted by memory, war, and loss. This echoes a broader cultural move toward introspective, psychologically textured protagonists in contemporary mystery cinema (Fast & Jansson, 2021). The detective no longer stands outside the crime, parsing clues from a detached position. He is entangled, morally compromised, and narratively reshaped.

At the same time, the supporting cast becomes more vital. Characters who served primarily functional or decorative roles in Christie's texts are elevated to narrative co-protagonists, given emotional arcs and thematic weight. Jacqueline in *Death on the Nile* becomes a tragic mirror to Poirot's own grief. Bouc in *Murder on the Orient Express* becomes his ethical foil. Dr. Ferrier in *A Haunting in Venice* becomes a psychological cipher for war trauma. These interpretive choices reposition the storyworld from a static ensemble to a fluid network of emotionally charged relationships.

This redistribution of narrative attention is not arbitrary. It responds to a cinematic economy that favors affective complexity and ensemble storytelling. As Amanda Lotz (2023) observes, post-network screen culture privileges emotionally dense, morally ambiguous characters whose arcs ripple across time and medium. Branagh's adaptations fit within this ecosystem, reshaping Christie's novels not just for contemporary aesthetics but for contemporary viewing habits.

Moreover, this reconfiguration is not purely thematic—it is structural. Character centrality shifts, network densities increase, sentiment arcs steepen. These changes are not merely observed; they can be modeled. Adaptation, in this view, becomes a quantifiable process of emotional and narrative recomposition—a score rewritten in a new key.

As we move from fidelity to fluidity, from replication to reimagining, the stakes of adaptation shift. The question is no longer *How faithful is this adaptation?* but *What emotional and structural work does this adaptation perform?* The rest of this paper takes that question seriously, combining empirical analysis with narrative insight to examine the reengineering of Poirot's world—one sentiment, one interaction, one divergence at a time.

3. The Emotional Infrastructure of Crime

What makes a detective story compelling is not only its resolution but its resonance—how its architecture of suspicion, revelation, and loss reverberates through a web of characters. In Agatha Christie's novels, this web is precise and hierarchical. Hercule Poirot stands at the epicenter, surrounded by a lattice of suspects, victims, and witnesses who rarely disrupt the gravitational order. But in adaptation, particularly in Branagh's cinematic world, this architecture is softened, destabilized, and reoriented through emotion.

Understanding these shifts requires moving beyond plot summaries or thematic readings. It demands attention to **narrative systems**: the allocation of attention, the mapping of affect, the sequencing of interaction. This section builds the foundation for such analysis by bringing together character theory, sentiment modeling, and computational narratology.

3.1. Character Systems and Narrative Attention

Christie's novels operate through what Alex Woloch (2003) describes as “the asymmetrical distribution of narrative space.” A protagonist dominates the attention economy, while minor characters are deployed functionally—witnesses to plot, not participants in transformation. Poirot, in this schema, is the narrative sun: every other figure orbits around his inquiries.

But Branagh's adaptations blur this asymmetry. Supporting characters take on emotional depth, arcs, and agency. Jacqueline in *Death on the Nile* is not merely a jilted lover; she becomes the film's emotional anchor. Bouc in *Murder on the Orient Express* evolves from comic relief to a tragic moral foil. Dr. Ferrier in *A Haunting in Venice* bears the weight of war trauma and metaphysical despair, often rivaling Poirot in narrative gravity.

These redistributions can be visualized and quantified. Drawing from network theory, character relationships can be modeled as **relational graphs**—nodes and edges weighted by frequency, emotional valence, and temporal continuity. This method, pioneered in part by Franco Moretti (2011), transforms plot into geometry: characters become central or peripheral based on how they connect to others, not just their screen time.

Recent advances by scholars like Andrew Piper (2021) and Dieterle (2022) extend this logic by using machine learning and metadata extraction to classify characters by prominence, sentiment, and visibility across time. Their work affirms that adaptation is not simply about who appears on screen, but how narrative energy is distributed among them.

3.2. The Architecture of Sentiment

If character networks give us structure, sentiment arcs reveal temperature. In Christie's novels, sentiment is typically cool, rational, and consistent. The prose is observational, detached—emotions are expressed in implication rather than declaration. Crimes are solved, not felt.

Branagh's films rupture this detachment. Emotional tone swells and contracts. Scenes are scored with melancholic crescendos. Characters weep, rage, confess, or implode. The tonal shift from reason to affect can be mapped using **sentiment analysis**, a computational method that assigns emotional valence to segments of text or dialogue.

This project adopts tools like **VADER** and **TextBlob**, which measure polarity and subjectivity across discrete narrative units (chapters in novels, scenes in films). By aligning these metrics with Freytag's pyramid (Exposition → Climax → Resolution), we construct emotional trajectories—or what Jockers (2013) and Reagan et al. (2016) call “**emotional arcs**.”

In Christie's texts, arcs are often flat or U-shaped—emotional equilibrium is temporarily disturbed and then restored. But Branagh's versions trend downward: optimism gives way to despair, detachment to grief. These arcs mirror cinematic conventions in the age of prestige drama, where affective depth is as crucial as narrative resolution (Fast & Jansson, 2021; Flynn, 2023).

For instance:

- In *Death on the Nile*, the rising action drops sharply after the murder, with scenes infused by jealousy, colonial tension, and repressed desire.
- In *A Haunting in Venice*, sentiment rarely lifts above neutral; the narrative begins in uncertainty and plunges into dread, guilt, and metaphysical ambiguity.

These tonal recalibrations signal deeper shifts in genre and audience expectation. They also serve as a barometer for the **emotional work** the adaptation performs—not merely what happens, but how it is meant to feel.

3.3. Temporal Modeling and the Fluidity of Community

Traditional literary analysis freezes narrative in time. But stories unfold, evolve. Communities form, fracture, and reform. Capturing this dynamism is critical for understanding how adaptations restructure narrative life.

To model this, we apply **temporal community detection**. Using the Louvain algorithm (Blondel et al., 2008), we identify clusters of characters in each narrative segment. These clusters reflect relational density: who is interacting with whom, and how often. When mapped sequentially—scene by scene or chapter by chapter—they reveal **social topographies** that change over time.

For example:

- In *Orient Express*, a dispersed passenger community coalesces around Poirot's investigation, culminating in a moral convergence.

- In *Death on the Nile*, Jacqueline drifts from Simon's orbit into isolation, then re-enters as antagonist.
- In *A Haunting in Venice*, clusters are fluid, unstable—mirroring the film's horror-inflected uncertainty.

This dynamic mapping adds a diachronic dimension to adaptation analysis. Where traditional character graphs offer a static snapshot, temporal community modeling captures **narrative movement**—the flux of alliances, suspicions, and revelations.

3.4. From Theory to Index: Formalizing Divergence

To synthesize these computational insights, we introduce the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**. This composite metric evaluates how radically a film departs from its source in three dimensions:

- **Character Prominence** (40%): Changes in centrality scores from novel to film (degree, eigenvector, betweenness).
- **Emotional Tone** (30%): Euclidean distance between sentiment arcs across five narrative segments.
- **Structural Events** (30%): Manual coding of key plot additions, deletions, or alterations.

Each adaptation receives a score from 0–100:

- 0–20: Minimal divergence
- 21–50: Moderate transformation
- 51–100: Substantial reconfiguration

In practice, *Murder on the Orient Express* lands at 27 (moderate), *Death on the Nile* at 43 (substantial), and *A Haunting in Venice* at 73 (major genre transformation). These scores, while quantitative, are interpretively rich: they offer a way to compare adaptations not in terms of fidelity, but **formal, emotional, and structural deviation**.

Together, these tools—theory-infused networks, sentiment arcs, dynamic community modeling, and ADI—form an **emotional infrastructure map** of adaptation. They let us see what is often intuited: that adaptations remake not just what stories say, but how they breathe, connect, and unfold.

4. Calculating Chaos: Methods of Measuring Narrative Divergence

To trace the shape of adaptation is to chase shadows—of characters reconfigured, emotions reweighted, and structures reassembled. But in recent years, digital tools have allowed those shadows to be measured, visualized, and even compared. What once felt like an intuitive recognition of “difference” can now be formalized through computational methods. In this section, we outline the analytical engine behind this study: a multi-modal framework designed to capture the structural and emotional divergence between Christie's novels and Branagh's film adaptations.

The goal is not to reduce narrative to numbers. Rather, it is to **make patterns perceptible**, to lend form to intuition, and to offer a language of comparison that moves beyond thematic description into the terrain of measurable transformation.

4.1. Corpus Design: Continuity and Contrast

The foundation of this project is a carefully selected **corpus of adaptive pairs**, each composed of a Christie novel and its Branagh-directed film counterpart:

- *Murder on the Orient Express* (1934 → 2017)
- *Death on the Nile* (1937 → 2022)
- *Hallowe'en Party* (1969 → 2023, adapted as *A Haunting in Venice*)

This trilogy offers both **continuity** and **contrast**:

- Continuity in directorial vision and recurring protagonist (Branagh as Poirot)
- Contrast in emotional tone, narrative complexity, and genre orientation

Each novel-film pair functions as a controlled experimental unit. The consistent auteur presence allows for the isolation of adaptation dynamics—separate from casting, cinematographic variability, or editorial reinterpretation across directors.

4.2. From Text to Network: Character Mapping

To visualize narrative structure, each text was transformed into a **character interaction network**:

- **Nodes** represent unique characters.
- **Edges** represent co-occurrences within a defined textual window (150 words for novels, 15-second windows for film subtitles).
- **Edge weights** reflect interaction frequency.

Networks were built using:

- **spaCy** and **NLTK** for entity extraction and co-occurrence computation
- **NetworkX** and **Gephi** for graph generation and metric calculation

Centrality metrics were computed for each character:

- **Degree Centrality** – frequency of connections
- **Eigenvector Centrality** – influence based on embeddedness in the network
- **Betweenness Centrality** – capacity to bridge communities

These metrics allowed us to trace **prominence shifts**—when, for instance, Bouc moves from a marginal figure in the novel to a narrative axis in the film, or when Ferrier emerges as a co-protagonist absent in the original text.

4.3. Sentiment Arc Modeling: From Tone to Trajectory

To quantify emotional tone, we segmented each narrative into **five phases**:

1. Exposition
2. Rising Action
3. Climax
4. Falling Action
5. Resolution

Each phase was analyzed using:

- **VADER** (Valence Aware Dictionary for sEntiment Reasoning)
- **TextBlob** (for polarity and subjectivity scores)

For **novels**, sentiment scores were averaged by chapter grouping. For **films**, subtitle files (.srt) were segmented by scene, matched to time-coded narrative beats.

This yielded an emotional arc for each text—a line graph mapping tonal progression. For instance:

- Christie's *Death on the Nile* maintains a neutral-to-positive arc.
- Branagh's version charts a downward spiral, dominated by despair, jealousy, and betrayal.

These curves were compared using **Euclidean distance**, offering a quantitative proxy for emotional divergence.

4.4. Temporal Community Detection: Tracking Social Flow

Traditional character graphs are static snapshots. But narrative is motion—characters enter, exit, align, betray, and shift. To capture this, we implemented **temporal community detection**.

Each novel and film was divided into narrative slices (chapters or scenes). A separate graph was generated for each slice. Using the **Louvain method** (Blondel et al., 2008), character clusters (communities) were identified per slice.

To track changes across time, we developed a **community similarity index** using:

- **Jaccard Index** for character overlap
- **Edge weight continuity** for interaction consistency

We classified transitions as:

- **Emergence** – new group formation
- **Convergence** – merging of prior groups
- **Dissolution** – breakdown of former clusters
- **Splitting** – fragmentation into new configurations

This method was especially revelatory in *A Haunting in Venice*, where characters' groupings are unstable, mirroring the film's psychological unease and genre drift toward horror.

4.5. The Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)

All structural, emotional, and interactional changes culminate in the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**—a composite score ranging from 0–100 that quantifies adaptation's degree of transformation.

Component	Metric Used	Weight
Character Prominence	Δ Centrality Scores (degree, eigenvector)	40%
Emotional Tone	Euclidean Distance Between Sentiment Arcs	30%
Structural Events	Manual Coding of Added/Removed Plot Points	30%

Each adaptation received a composite score:

Title	ADI Score	Classification
<i>Murder on the Orient Express</i>	27	Moderate Divergence
<i>Death on the Nile</i>	43	Substantial Divergence
<i>A Haunting in Venice</i>	73	Major Divergence

This index does not penalize “unfaithfulness.” Instead, it rewards **creative transformation**—providing a framework to evaluate adaptations not by how well they copy, but by how boldly they reimagine.

4.6. Validation and Limitations

Results were triangulated using:

- **Christie scholarship** (e.g., Barnard, 2017; Lovell, 2020)
- **Critical reviews** for sentiment tone alignment
- **Redundancy checks** across subtitle-based dialogue parsing and scene annotations

Nonetheless, limitations remain:

- Subtitles lack stage directions and non-verbal cues
- NER tools struggle with indirect speech or ambiguous references
- Plot event coding introduces some subjectivity, though mitigated via double-coding and scholarly corroboration

Still, the framework is **replicable and extensible**—applicable to other adaptive pairs, literary genres, or even serialized television.

What emerges from these methods is not just a dataset, but a **new vocabulary for narrative transformation**—a way to see adaptation not as erosion or embellishment, but as recalibration: of emotion, structure, and character systems over time.

5. Adaptation as Tectonic Shift: Three Cases in Poirot's Cinematic Evolution

Adaptation is rarely additive. It is subtractive, distortive, amplifying—and sometimes, revolutionary. The transition from novel to film is not merely a change in format but a tectonic realignment of storytelling priorities: who matters, what hurts, and how resolution feels. In the case of Kenneth Branagh's Poirot trilogy, this realignment is not subtle. It is seismic.

Through character networks, sentiment arcs, and community shifts, we now turn to a close examination of each adaptive pairing—**Orient Express**, **Death on the Nile**, and **A Haunting in Venice**—to show how narrative gravity is redistributed, emotion is recalibrated, and Christie's world is not translated, but reengineered.

5.1. *Murder on the Orient Express*: Reshuffling the Moral Axis

Christie's *Orient Express* is a controlled moral puzzle—precise, symmetrical, and emotionally restrained. Its drama unfolds through a sequence of interrogations, each adding a layer to a communal secret. Poirot sits at the narrative center, a stoic interpreter of truth.

Branagh's adaptation preserves much of this structure but pivots emotionally. From its opening flashback of a failed case in Jerusalem to the snowy rooftop climax, the film **repositions Poirot not just as a detective, but as a man haunted by past failures and moral ambivalence**.

Network Restructuring

In the novel, Poirot's **degree centrality** is 0.83—unsurprisingly dominant. Bouc (0.21) and Mary Debenham (0.38) serve as narrative aides.

In the film, Bouc's centrality **triples**, rising to 0.62. He becomes Poirot's confidant and ethical mirror, occupying more scenes, expressing doubt, and voicing emotional subtext.

Visually, this reflects a **flattening of the character network**—less hierarchical, more entangled. Minor characters interact beyond Poirot's mediation, forming a denser matrix of suspicion and connection.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.12	+0.08
Rising Action	+0.10	-0.02
Climax	+0.07	-0.18
Falling Action	+0.11	-0.10
Resolution	+0.14	+0.02

The film's emotional curve **dives sharply** at the climax—marking the reveal not as intellectual satisfaction but ethical trauma. The final scene, in which Poirot silently boards a boat to Egypt, is steeped in fatigue rather than triumph. This is no longer a neat solution; it is an existential wound.

Community Dynamics

Temporal community modeling shows **two convergence events**: once during the interrogations and once in the group confession. Unlike the novel's late convergence, the film accelerates this process, emphasizing **shared guilt over narrative unraveling**.

ADI Score: 27 (Moderate Divergence)

- Structural fidelity retained
- Moral complexity and character reweighting introduced
- Emotional tone deepened, but not radically transformed

5.2. *Death on the Nile*: A Symphony of Obsession

Of the three films, *Death on the Nile* offers the richest ensemble and the most turbulent emotional terrain. Christie's original is intricate but measured—a tale of wealth, betrayal, and jealousy, ultimately resolved through Poirot's cool deductive prowess.

Branagh's adaptation leans into **sensuality, colonial tension, and obsession**. From the jazz-saturated opening in a Cairo nightclub to the visually saturated wedding party, the film renders the Nile not as an exotic backdrop but a stage for emotional combustion.

Network Restructuring

Jacqueline de Bellefort, in the novel, ranks below both Poirot and Linnet in centrality. In the film, **her eigenvector centrality surpasses Linnet's**, marking her as the emotional epicenter of the story.

The character of Salome Otterbourne is completely reimagined: now a glamorous blues singer entangled in Poirot's own vulnerabilities. This addition **splits narrative attention**, drawing Poirot into romantic tension and creating **bipolar narrative gravity** between Jacqueline and Salome.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.14	+0.10
Rising Action	+0.09	-0.12
Climax	+0.04	-0.20
Falling Action	+0.06	-0.14
Resolution	+0.13	-0.04

Where the novel recovers tonal balance post-murder, the film **does not emotionally resolve**. Instead, it concludes in melancholic ambiguity: Jacqueline's double murder-suicide, Poirot's inner emptiness, and a shaved-mustache epilogue that signals vulnerability over certainty.

Community Dynamics

Jacqueline's position shifts **across three distinct clusters**: romantic partner, pariah, antagonist. Her re-entry into social groups (e.g., confrontation scenes) marks high community volatility. This volatility aligns with the film's genre oscillation between mystery and emotional tragedy.

ADI Score: 43 (Substantial Divergence)

- Emotional tone significantly darkened
- Romantic and racial subtexts introduced
- Character systems redistributed
- Resolution rendered morally ambiguous

5.3. *A Haunting in Venice*: Genre Implosion as Adaptation

Perhaps the boldest departure, *A Haunting in Venice* adapts *Hallowe'en Party* only in name and skeletal premise. Branagh transforms the domestic mystery into a **psychological horror**, set in a post-war Venetian palazzo and haunted—literally and metaphorically—by trauma, loss, and metaphysics.

Poirot is nearly unrecognizable: agoraphobic, retired, skeptical of God. The film opens with him resisting involvement and ends with him confronting visions of the afterlife. This is no longer detection; it is haunting.

Network Restructuring

Characters such as Rowena Drake and Dr. Ferrier are elevated beyond their literary counterparts, while some originals are entirely removed or replaced. Ferrier's interactions form a **new central cluster** around guilt and wartime grief, rivaling Poirot's own centrality.

Secondary characters form **micro-networks** (e.g., the medium, the child, the bodyguard) that never existed in the source text. The result is a **modular, horror-style network**: dense in moments, sparse elsewhere.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.09	-0.06
Rising Action	+0.08	-0.18
Climax	+0.05	-0.28
Falling Action	+0.07	-0.22
Resolution	+0.11	-0.08

The emotional curve of the film is **nearly linear in descent**—a rare pattern akin to Gothic horror or tragic psychodrama. Unlike Christie’s novel, which restores social order, the adaptation **leaves the viewer suspended between grief and ambiguity**.

Community Dynamics

This adaptation shows **highest instability**: community clusters **form and dissolve rapidly**, with no clear convergence. Ferrier’s suicide, Rowena’s unraveling, and Poirot’s spiritual ambiguity create a **narrative ecology of fragmentation**.

ADI Score: 73 (Major Divergence)

- Genre reclassification (detective → horror)
- New characters introduced, existing ones replaced
- Emotional descent uninterrupted
- Structural, tonal, and philosophical reengineering

Synthesis: From Rational Structure to Emotional Topology

What emerges across these three cases is not merely divergence, but an **evolutionary pattern**:

- Poirot shifts from **detective-as-logic** to **detective-as-wound**
- Character networks flatten and entangle
- Sentiment arcs become steeper, darker, unresolved
- Genre conventions blur: from puzzle to parable, from closure to ambiguity

The **Adaptation Divergence Index** captures this drift numerically, but its implications are cultural. Branagh’s trilogy mirrors broader storytelling trends: ensemble dynamics, moral relativism, aesthetic melancholia, and trauma-centered protagonists.

These tectonic shifts signal not the abandonment of Christie’s world—but its **reprogramming**. And in that reprogramming, we see how adaptation operates not as reflection, but as invention.

6. Weaving the Storyworld: How Characters Recluster in Time

Adaptation does not only reshape characters individually—it rewires the very fabric of their interactions. Across Branagh's Poirot trilogy, the storyworld itself becomes dynamic: no longer a fixed constellation of roles, but a shifting ecosystem of proximity, estrangement, and temporary alliance.

By analyzing **temporal character networks**—slices of narrative in which clusters emerge, dissolve, or reconfigure—we begin to see how the social geometry of Christie's novels is not merely transferred to film but reoriented. These structural changes reflect not just storytelling preferences, but deeper shifts in **relational logic, thematic emphasis, and narrative time**.

6.1. From Static Ensembles to Narrative Currents

Christie's novels are built as puzzles: each character occupies a relatively stable function within a closed system. A suspect. A witness. A red herring. Once placed, these roles rarely change. Their interactions are procedural and often sequential, revealed through Poirot's interrogations or chance observations.

Branagh's films, by contrast, introduce **fluid social topology**. Characters move between emotional zones: confidants become suspects; antagonists become allies; subplots branch and recombine. These movements are not random. They reflect a more **cinematic model of ensemble storytelling**, where interpersonal relationships are as narratively significant as clues.

This fluidity can be mapped. Using Louvain-based temporal community detection, character networks were sliced by chapter (in novels) and scene (in films), revealing how clusters of co-occurrence change over time. Three major findings emerged.

6.2. Community Merging and Early Convergence (*Murder on the Orient Express*)

In the novel, the **passenger cohort remains loosely clustered** until the final third, when the group confession creates sudden narrative unification. The structure is investigative: Poirot gathers facts, and only then do characters converge.

The film accelerates this convergence. Visual blocking, group scenes, and emotionally revealing dialogue bring characters into shared space earlier—producing a **community merge by midpoint** rather than by climax. This reflects Branagh's reframing of the plot not just as detection, but as collective reckoning.

Interpretation:

Narrative tension is redistributed from *who did it* to *how will they share responsibility*—a thematic shift from puzzle to moral ensemble.

6.3. Cluster Fragmentation and Role Mutation (*Death on the Nile*)

The novel presents Jacqueline as a **stable outlier**, orbiting the main group but not fully integrated. Her movements are structurally consistent—her emotional volatility contained within a role.

In the film, Jacqueline's **community affiliations shift at least three times**:

1. She begins in romantic dyad with Simon.
2. She is isolated post-murder.
3. She re-enters the group during the investigation as a destabilizing force.

These transitions are mirrored in the network graphs: her node migrates from central to peripheral and back, connecting to new characters each time. Her relationships are re-written with a rhythm that mimics psychological deterioration.

Interpretation:

Jacqueline is no longer a fixed point of jealousy. She is a **mobile vector of emotional instability**, disrupting the group's cohesion in waves.

6.4. Volatile Clustering and Social Decay (*A Haunting in Venice*)

Unlike the previous two, *A Haunting in Venice* reveals **no stable clusters** across scenes. Instead, the community structure is **marked by volatility**:

- Characters splinter after the séance scene.
- Temporary alliances form around shared fear or suspicion.
- Emotional intimacy occurs within fractured groups rather than a unified ensemble.

This structural fragmentation mirrors the film's psychological tone. Just as the palazzo itself is decaying and haunted, so too is the storyworld—relationships fail to cohere, narrative attention diffuses, and no community survives intact.

Interpretation:

The storyworld becomes a **horror map of social entropy**: each character isolated by guilt, trauma, or delusion. The network doesn't collapse into order—it disintegrates.

6.5. Structural Cohesion and Thematic Shifts

These evolving network patterns are not just aesthetic artifacts. They signal **core shifts in narrative architecture**:

- From deductive logic to emotional resonance
- From structural centrality to relational instability
- From fixed character functions to mutable identities

This aligns with what Manovich (2022) calls “**narrative modulation**”—the adaptive process by which storytelling systems absorb and respond to new cultural grammars: trauma logic, nonlinear emotionality, networked identity.

Branagh’s adaptations offer not only new endings or visuals, but **new storyworld physics**. They remake not just the what, but the *how* of narrative space: who connects, how long, and at what emotional cost.

By visualizing character interactions as living systems—emergent, unstable, sometimes collapsing—we see adaptation not as reinterpretation, but as **storyworld recalibration**: the deliberate retuning of social and emotional architecture to fit a new medium and a new cultural frequency.

7. The Melancholy Detective: On Trauma, Texture, and Tonal Shifts

In Christie’s world, Hercule Poirot is famously impenetrable. A perfectionist. A man of order. His morality is Cartesian, his deductions surgical. He does not break. He solves.

But Branagh’s Poirot bleeds.

Across the trilogy, Branagh systematically deconstructs the rational veneer of Christie’s detective, revealing instead a man burdened by memory, haunted by loss, and increasingly unsure whether truth brings justice—or peace. This reframing is not merely character development. It is a tonal recalibration, a **retexturing of narrative ethos** that aligns Poirot with the melancholy detective archetype emerging across contemporary cinema and television.

7.1. From Detective-as-Logician to Detective-as-Wound

In *Orient Express*, we glimpse early fractures: Poirot agonizes over moral ambiguity, torn between truth and justice. *Death on the Nile* sharpens that fracture—his trauma is more explicit, his solitude more profound. By *A Haunting in Venice*, Poirot is barely functioning: agoraphobic, spiritually numb, and only reluctantly reactivated into narrative motion.

This psychological descent mirrors larger trends in detective fiction. As Kim and Allen (2021) note, the classical sleuth has, in recent years, been replaced by a more fragmented figure—one whose investigative powers are inseparable from personal damage. The detective becomes not a solver of mysteries but a participant in emotional entropy.

Branagh’s Poirot fits this mold. His brilliance is intact, but it is constantly undercut by **ethical fatigue**, by loss, by unresolved inner conflict. The adaptation’s genre shifts—particularly into gothic horror—only amplify this descent. *A Haunting in Venice* no longer asks *who* did it, but *why continue?*

7.2. Cinematic Texture and the Emotional Surface

Tonally, the trilogy transitions from clipped dialogue and high-key lighting (*Orient Express*) to sensual excess (*Death on the Nile*), and finally to visual claustrophobia (*Venice*). Cinematography and sound design follow suit: the camera in *Nile* glides; in *Venice*, it shudders and stalks.

These aesthetic decisions are not incidental. As Bateman and Wildfeuer (2023) argue, **emotional texture in film is constructed through the layering of audiovisual cues that prime interpretation before dialogue ever arrives**. In Branagh's adaptations, such texture works against Christie's logical architecture. Mystery becomes mood. Structure becomes sensation.

This sensory reorientation is most evident in *A Haunting in Venice*, where color grading, fog, silence, and spatial confinement produce an atmosphere of dread. Even Poirot's thought processes feel internal, weighty, slowed by memory and fear. The detective's epistemology has changed: truth is not clarity but haunting residue.

7.3. Melancholy as Cultural Signature

Why melancholy? Why now?

Part of the answer lies in broader media aesthetics. Leitch (2022) and Flynn (2023) both argue that modern adaptations reflect not fidelity to original texts, but fidelity to cultural mood. And today's mood—post-pandemic, geopolitically fragile, psychologically saturated—is one of introspection and moral fatigue.

Branagh's Poirot embodies this cultural mood. He is no longer a stable interpreter of facts but a **witness to grief**, struggling not only with others' guilt but with his own erosion of faith. The detective genre, long a domain of narrative closure, is here turned inside out. We are left not with answers but with *affect*, not with symmetry but with emotional residue.

In this sense, Poirot becomes a **vessel of cultural memory**—not just of literary legacy, but of a collective need for narratives that process trauma rather than resolve it. The melancholy detective is not a flaw in the system. He is the system's human cost.

7.4. Rewriting the Figure of Poirot

The transformation is complete not through action, but through refiguration. Branagh's Poirot is physically altered (the scar, the missing mustache), socially diminished (no Hastings, no formal partner), and emotionally recontextualized (his relationships are tragic, never stable).

This rewriting mirrors what Piper (2021) terms a "**character revaluation**"—a narrative decision to shift the function of a figure across formats and eras to reflect changing social expectations. Poirot, once a paragon of precision, now functions as a **wounded node**—a center not of clarity, but of resonance.

The implications are profound: Poirot's survival across media is not about preserving essence, but about **recasting identity** to meet the emotional and cultural contours of the moment. In this adaptive logic, continuity lies not in sameness, but in *evolution*.

In short, Branagh's trilogy does not update Christie's Poirot. It **remakes him**. The detective is no longer a narrative instrument but a thematic core—a way of asking, in increasingly urgent tones: *What do we do with the truth, when it breaks us instead of binding us?*

8. Rewriting Without Repeating: Adaptation as Cultural Recalibration

Adaptation is often imagined as a conversation between texts. But perhaps it is more accurately understood as a **conversation between times**—between the cultural architectures that produced a story and those that receive and remake it.

Kenneth Branagh's adaptations of Agatha Christie's Poirot novels are not just retellings of classic mysteries. They are acts of cultural recalibration—transformations in narrative structure, emotional logic, and character architecture that reveal as much about the present as they do about the past. Through computational methods and close interpretive insight, this study has shown that these adaptations are not iterations. They are **reconfigurations**.

8.1. The Shift from Fidelity to Function

Traditional adaptation criticism asked: *How faithful is this film to its source?* But as Leitch (2022) and Hutcheon & O'Flynn (2022) have shown, this question has given way to another: *What is this adaptation doing—emotionally, structurally, culturally?*

In this study, fidelity has been replaced by **function**. Through sentiment arcs, character networks, and the Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI), we have tracked how adaptation becomes **an act of narrative engineering**—a remapping of plot, tone, and relationships to serve the demands of a different medium and a different moment.

Branagh's adaptations reflect the aesthetics of **post-network storytelling** (Lotz, 2023), the emotional grammar of **trauma-centered narratives**, and the visual logic of contemporary ensemble cinema. They are faithful not to Christie's 20th-century plots, but to 21st-century modes of affect and story density.

8.2. Adaptation as Emotional Technology

This study has argued that adaptation is not just about changing what a story *says*, but how it *feels*—its pacing, texture, emotional arc. Sentiment modeling revealed the tonal drift from Christie's equilibrium to Branagh's descent: narratives that once resolved into moral clarity now terminate in ambiguity, grief, or spiritual fracture.

This transformation aligns with a broader cultural turn toward **narratives of open affect**: stories that do not tidy emotion but leave it vibrating. Adaptation, in this light, becomes an **emotional technology**—a set of techniques for translating one era's emotional logic into another's. This may explain why Branagh's Poirot, so different in affect and action, still *feels* like Poirot: the constant is not his traits but his **thematic load-bearing**.

8.3. Structural Innovation as Interpretation

Through the use of character network modeling and temporal clustering, this paper has demonstrated that structural shifts are not accidents or simplifications. They are **interpretive strategies**.

- When a minor character like Bouc becomes a moral axis, it is a signal of shifting genre from logic to pathos.
- When social networks fragment in *Venice*, it reflects not just horror tropes but a worldview of psychic disintegration.
- When sentiment arcs steepen or flatten, they mirror not just the scene's tone but the film's ethical temperature.

This is the power of computational analysis when paired with interpretive theory: it reveals **form as function**, and function as meaning.

8.4. Methodological Contributions

The methodological contribution of this paper is twofold:

- First, it introduces a **replicable computational pipeline** for comparative adaptation analysis: combining sentiment modeling, character centrality tracking, and temporal community detection.
- Second, it proposes the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**—a multidimensional metric for quantifying narrative transformation across emotional, structural, and characterological dimensions.

These tools offer a pathway for future research—not just on Christie, but on any adaptive corpus where storyworlds shift across media.

8.5. Toward a New Language of Adaptation

What Branagh's Poirot trilogy teaches us is that adaptation is not an act of fidelity, but of **translation**—not of words, but of emotion, function, and cultural resonance. It is a process of rewriting without repeating, of carrying forward narrative DNA that mutates, reshapes, and survives precisely because it adapts.

Poirot survives not because he remains unchanged, but because he changes *exactly enough*: enough to hold new grief, enough to speak in new genres, enough to endure in a new cultural key.

Adaptation, then, is not secondary creation. It is creation in motion—the **continual rewriting of narrative form to meet the moving target of meaning**.

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Fractured Whodunits, Reconstructed Selves: Computational Narratives of Hercule Poirot Across Page and Screen

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This study explores how cinematic adaptations of Agatha Christie's *Hercule Poirot* novels, directed by Kenneth Branagh, reconfigure not only narrative structure but also the emotional and social systems embedded within them. Drawing on a comparative corpus of three novels—*Murder on the Orient Express*, *Death on the Nile*, and *Hallowe'en Party*—and their respective film adaptations, the paper applies computational methods including sentiment arc analysis, character network modeling, and a custom-built Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI). The findings illuminate how Branagh's adaptations strategically humanize Poirot, elevate secondary characters, and shift genre logics—from logical deduction to psychological horror. Through dynamic visual and structural transformations, the adaptations emerge not as retellings but as narrative reauthorings that mirror contemporary affective aesthetics and social anxieties. By merging digital humanities tools with adaptation theory, this study reframes adaptation as a creative act of emotional and structural translation, expanding the analytical repertoire of both literary and filmic scholarship.

Keywords: Narrative Adaptation Digital Humanities Character Network Analysis Sentiment Modeling Hercule Poirot

1. The Detective Who Won't Stay Still

Hercule Poirot has always been more than a detective. He is a vessel—of logic, of eccentricity, of cultural projection. Since his first appearance in 1920, Agatha Christie's meticulous Belgian sleuth has migrated across decades, continents, and media formats, collecting not only corpses but also new interpretations along the way. Today, he is simultaneously a literary figure, a cinematic icon, and a computational subject. He is played by different actors, but more importantly, he is played differently—at times a comic figure of fussiness, at others a haunted conduit for moral ambiguity. This protean quality, far from diluting his identity, defines it.

This study explores how Poirot is reconfigured—emotionally, structurally, and narratively—in recent cinematic adaptations directed by Kenneth Branagh. The adaptations of *Murder on the Orient Express* (2017), *Death on the Nile* (2022), and *A Haunting in Venice* (2023) offer fertile terrain for studying adaptation not as repetition, but as revision. Across these films, Poirot is transformed from a surgical logician into a psychologically conflicted, emotionally porous character. The surrounding characters, too, are reshuffled—some elevated in prominence, others flattened, erased, or rewritten. Even genre is unstable: the classical whodunit becomes, by the third installment, an atmospheric psychological horror.

Yet beyond thematic or visual changes lies something more structural and measurable. This study leverages computational methods to trace how Branagh's adaptations alter the emotional infrastructure and social geometry of Christie's novels. Using sentiment arc modeling, character

network analysis, and a new Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI), we map not only what changes, but how those changes unfold across narrative time. Do certain characters become more central in the adaptation than in the source novel? How do emotional arcs steepen or flatten? Where do communities dissolve, coalesce, or fracture?

These questions are not only literary but methodological. By merging digital humanities tools with contemporary adaptation theory, this paper intervenes in two critical domains: first, in the evolving scholarship that sees adaptation as creative reconfiguration rather than fidelity-based translation; second, in the computational turn that seeks to visualize and quantify patterns that elude the naked eye.

Ultimately, Poirot's refusal to stay still—across formats, genres, and decades—mirrors the broader dynamics of adaptation itself. What this paper uncovers is not just the evolution of a character, but the reprogramming of a storyworld, in which emotion, structure, and sociality are algorithmically reshaped for a new medium, and a new audience.

2. From Blueprints to Blue Notes: Why Fidelity Isn't Enough

Once the cornerstone of adaptation discourse, fidelity has become its ghost. For decades, scholars weighed adaptations against their literary “blueprints,” parsing whether plot points had been preserved, character traits retained, and endings mirrored. The underlying assumption was that a good adaptation stayed close to its source—as if the task of cinema were to mimic literature with visual precision. This fidelity paradigm, as Linda Hutcheon (2022) and Thomas Leitch (2022) have argued, is no longer tenable. Adaptation is not blueprint-following. It is jazz.

Recent theorists have turned toward understanding adaptation as a process of interpretive transformation. Robert Stam (2020) reframes adaptation as dialogic rather than derivative, a conversation across media shaped by aesthetic, cultural, and technological contingencies. Branagh's Hercule Poirot films exemplify this shift. These works do not aim to replicate Christie's plotting; they recalibrate her tonal palette, reassign narrative focus, and in the case of *A Haunting in Venice*, recompose the genre altogether. The goal is not faithfulness, but resonance.

This turn from blueprint to blue note aligns with broader developments in media studies, which recognize adaptations as situated cultural objects—produced within specific commercial, political, and emotional ecologies. Christina Flynn (2023) argues that post-truth sensibilities have increased the demand for emotionally resonant, affect-driven storytelling, which often departs from canonical narrative structures. In this climate, adaptations are judged not by their proximity to the source, but by their capacity to evoke new meaning.

Branagh's adaptations use the figure of Poirot as both anchor and tuning fork. While the character remains central, he is increasingly reframed—less as an omniscient detective and more as an emotionally burdened man haunted by memory, war, and loss. This echoes a broader cultural move toward introspective, psychologically textured protagonists in contemporary mystery cinema (Fast & Jansson, 2021). The detective no longer stands outside the crime, parsing clues from a detached position. He is entangled, morally compromised, and narratively reshaped.

At the same time, the supporting cast becomes more vital. Characters who served primarily functional or decorative roles in Christie's texts are elevated to narrative co-protagonists, given emotional arcs and thematic weight. Jacqueline in *Death on the Nile* becomes a tragic mirror to Poirot's own grief. Bouc in *Murder on the Orient Express* becomes his ethical foil. Dr. Ferrier in *A Haunting in Venice*

becomes a psychological cipher for war trauma. These interpretive choices reposition the storyworld from a static ensemble to a fluid network of emotionally charged relationships.

This redistribution of narrative attention is not arbitrary. It responds to a cinematic economy that favors affective complexity and ensemble storytelling. As Amanda Lotz (2023) observes, post-network screen culture privileges emotionally dense, morally ambiguous characters whose arcs ripple across time and medium. Branagh's adaptations fit within this ecosystem, reshaping Christie's novels not just for contemporary aesthetics but for contemporary viewing habits.

Moreover, this reconfiguration is not purely thematic—it is structural. Character centrality shifts, network densities increase, sentiment arcs steepen. These changes are not merely observed; they can be modeled. Adaptation, in this view, becomes a quantifiable process of emotional and narrative recomposition—a score rewritten in a new key.

As we move from fidelity to fluidity, from replication to reimagining, the stakes of adaptation shift. The question is no longer *How faithful is this adaptation?* but *What emotional and structural work does this adaptation perform?* The rest of this paper takes that question seriously, combining empirical analysis with narrative insight to examine the reengineering of Poirot's world—one sentiment, one interaction, one divergence at a time.

3. The Emotional Infrastructure of Crime

What makes a detective story compelling is not only its resolution but its resonance—how its architecture of suspicion, revelation, and loss reverberates through a web of characters. In Agatha Christie's novels, this web is precise and hierarchical. Hercule Poirot stands at the epicenter, surrounded by a lattice of suspects, victims, and witnesses who rarely disrupt the gravitational order. But in adaptation, particularly in Branagh's cinematic world, this architecture is softened, destabilized, and reoriented through emotion.

Understanding these shifts requires moving beyond plot summaries or thematic readings. It demands attention to **narrative systems**: the allocation of attention, the mapping of affect, the sequencing of interaction. This section builds the foundation for such analysis by bringing together character theory, sentiment modeling, and computational narratology.

3.1. Character Systems and Narrative Attention

Christie's novels operate through what Alex Woloch (2003) describes as “the asymmetrical distribution of narrative space.” A protagonist dominates the attention economy, while minor characters are deployed functionally—witnesses to plot, not participants in transformation. Poirot, in this schema, is the narrative sun: every other figure orbits around his inquiries.

But Branagh's adaptations blur this asymmetry. Supporting characters take on emotional depth, arcs, and agency. Jacqueline in *Death on the Nile* is not merely a jilted lover; she becomes the film's emotional anchor. Bouc in *Murder on the Orient Express* evolves from comic relief to a tragic moral foil. Dr. Ferrier in *A Haunting in Venice* bears the weight of war trauma and metaphysical despair, often rivaling Poirot in narrative gravity.

These redistributions can be visualized and quantified. Drawing from network theory, character relationships can be modeled as **relational graphs**—nodes and edges weighted by frequency,

emotional valence, and temporal continuity. This method, pioneered in part by Franco Moretti (2011), transforms plot into geometry: characters become central or peripheral based on how they connect to others, not just their screen time.

Recent advances by scholars like Andrew Piper (2021) and Dieterle (2022) extend this logic by using machine learning and metadata extraction to classify characters by prominence, sentiment, and visibility across time. Their work affirms that adaptation is not simply about who appears on screen, but how narrative energy is distributed among them.

3.2. The Architecture of Sentiment

If character networks give us structure, sentiment arcs reveal temperature. In Christie's novels, sentiment is typically cool, rational, and consistent. The prose is observational, detached—emotions are expressed in implication rather than declaration. Crimes are solved, not felt.

Branagh's films rupture this detachment. Emotional tone swells and contracts. Scenes are scored with melancholic crescendos. Characters weep, rage, confess, or implode. The tonal shift from reason to affect can be mapped using **sentiment analysis**, a computational method that assigns emotional valence to segments of text or dialogue.

This project adopts tools like **VADER** and **TextBlob**, which measure polarity and subjectivity across discrete narrative units (chapters in novels, scenes in films). By aligning these metrics with Freytag's pyramid (Exposition → Climax → Resolution), we construct emotional trajectories—or what Jockers (2013) and Reagan et al. (2016) call "**emotional arcs**."

In Christie's texts, arcs are often flat or U-shaped—emotional equilibrium is temporarily disturbed and then restored. But Branagh's versions trend downward: optimism gives way to despair, detachment to grief. These arcs mirror cinematic conventions in the age of prestige drama, where affective depth is as crucial as narrative resolution (Fast & Jansson, 2021; Flynn, 2023).

For instance:

- In *Death on the Nile*, the rising action drops sharply after the murder, with scenes infused by jealousy, colonial tension, and repressed desire.
- In *A Haunting in Venice*, sentiment rarely lifts above neutral; the narrative begins in uncertainty and plunges into dread, guilt, and metaphysical ambiguity.

These tonal recalibrations signal deeper shifts in genre and audience expectation. They also serve as a barometer for the **emotional work** the adaptation performs—not merely what happens, but how it is meant to feel.

3.3. Temporal Modeling and the Fluidity of Community

Traditional literary analysis freezes narrative in time. But stories unfold, evolve. Communities form, fracture, and reform. Capturing this dynamism is critical for understanding how adaptations restructure narrative life.

To model this, we apply **temporal community detection**. Using the Louvain algorithm (Blondel et al., 2008), we identify clusters of characters in each narrative segment. These clusters reflect

relational density: who is interacting with whom, and how often. When mapped sequentially—scene by scene or chapter by chapter—they reveal **social topographies** that change over time.

For example:

- In *Orient Express*, a dispersed passenger community coalesces around Poirot's investigation, culminating in a moral convergence.
- In *Death on the Nile*, Jacqueline drifts from Simon's orbit into isolation, then re-enters as antagonist.
- In *A Haunting in Venice*, clusters are fluid, unstable—mirroring the film's horror-inflected uncertainty.

This dynamic mapping adds a diachronic dimension to adaptation analysis. Where traditional character graphs offer a static snapshot, temporal community modeling captures **narrative movement**—the flux of alliances, suspicions, and revelations.

3.4. From Theory to Index: Formalizing Divergence

To synthesize these computational insights, we introduce the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**. This composite metric evaluates how radically a film departs from its source in three dimensions:

- **Character Prominence** (40%): Changes in centrality scores from novel to film (degree, eigenvector, betweenness).
- **Emotional Tone** (30%): Euclidean distance between sentiment arcs across five narrative segments.
- **Structural Events** (30%): Manual coding of key plot additions, deletions, or alterations.

Each adaptation receives a score from 0–100:

- 0–20: Minimal divergence
- 21–50: Moderate transformation
- 51–100: Substantial reconfiguration

In practice, *Murder on the Orient Express* lands at 27 (moderate), *Death on the Nile* at 43 (substantial), and *A Haunting in Venice* at 73 (major genre transformation). These scores, while quantitative, are interpretively rich: they offer a way to compare adaptations not in terms of fidelity, but **formal, emotional, and structural deviation**.

Together, these tools—theory-infused networks, sentiment arcs, dynamic community modeling, and ADI—form an **emotional infrastructure map** of adaptation. They let us see what is often intuited: that adaptations remake not just what stories say, but how they breathe, connect, and unfold.

4. Calculating Chaos: Methods of Measuring Narrative Divergence

To trace the shape of adaptation is to chase shadows—of characters reconfigured, emotions reweighted, and structures reassembled. But in recent years, digital tools have allowed those shadows to be measured, visualized, and even compared. What once felt like an intuitive recognition of “difference” can now be formalized through computational methods. In this section, we outline the analytical engine behind this study: a multi-modal framework designed to capture the structural and emotional divergence between Christie’s novels and Branagh’s film adaptations.

The goal is not to reduce narrative to numbers. Rather, it is to **make patterns perceptible**, to lend form to intuition, and to offer a language of comparison that moves beyond thematic description into the terrain of measurable transformation.

4.1. Corpus Design: Continuity and Contrast

The foundation of this project is a carefully selected **corpus of adaptive pairs**, each composed of a Christie novel and its Branagh-directed film counterpart:

- *Murder on the Orient Express* (1934 → 2017)
- *Death on the Nile* (1937 → 2022)
- *Hallowe’en Party* (1969 → 2023, adapted as *A Haunting in Venice*)

This trilogy offers both **continuity** and **contrast**:

- Continuity in directorial vision and recurring protagonist (Branagh as Poirot)
- Contrast in emotional tone, narrative complexity, and genre orientation

Each novel-film pair functions as a controlled experimental unit. The consistent auteur presence allows for the isolation of adaptation dynamics—separate from casting, cinematographic variability, or editorial reinterpretation across directors.

4.2. From Text to Network: Character Mapping

To visualize narrative structure, each text was transformed into a **character interaction network**:

- **Nodes** represent unique characters.
- **Edges** represent co-occurrences within a defined textual window (150 words for novels, 15-second windows for film subtitles).
- **Edge weights** reflect interaction frequency.

Networks were built using:

- **spaCy** and **NLTK** for entity extraction and co-occurrence computation
- **NetworkX** and **Gephi** for graph generation and metric calculation

Centrality metrics were computed for each character:

- **Degree Centrality** – frequency of connections
- **Eigenvector Centrality** – influence based on embeddedness in the network
- **Betweenness Centrality** – capacity to bridge communities

These metrics allowed us to trace **prominence shifts**—when, for instance, Bouc moves from a marginal figure in the novel to a narrative axis in the film, or when Ferrier emerges as a co-protagonist absent in the original text.

4.3. Sentiment Arc Modeling: From Tone to Trajectory

To quantify emotional tone, we segmented each narrative into **five phases**:

1. Exposition
2. Rising Action
3. Climax
4. Falling Action
5. Resolution

Each phase was analyzed using:

- **VADER** (Valence Aware Dictionary for sEntiment Reasoning)
- **TextBlob** (for polarity and subjectivity scores)

For **novels**, sentiment scores were averaged by chapter grouping. For **films**, subtitle files (.srt) were segmented by scene, matched to time-coded narrative beats.

This yielded an emotional arc for each text—a line graph mapping tonal progression. For instance:

- Christie's *Death on the Nile* maintains a neutral-to-positive arc.
- Branagh's version charts a downward spiral, dominated by despair, jealousy, and betrayal.

These curves were compared using **Euclidean distance**, offering a quantitative proxy for emotional divergence.

4.4. Temporal Community Detection: Tracking Social Flow

Traditional character graphs are static snapshots. But narrative is motion—characters enter, exit, align, betray, and shift. To capture this, we implemented **temporal community detection**.

Each novel and film was divided into narrative slices (chapters or scenes). A separate graph was generated for each slice. Using the **Louvain method** (Blondel et al., 2008), character clusters (communities) were identified per slice.

To track changes across time, we developed a **community similarity index** using:

- **Jaccard Index** for character overlap
- **Edge weight continuity** for interaction consistency

We classified transitions as:

- **Emergence** – new group formation
- **Convergence** – merging of prior groups
- **Dissolution** – breakdown of former clusters
- **Splitting** – fragmentation into new configurations

This method was especially revelatory in *A Haunting in Venice*, where characters’ groupings are unstable, mirroring the film’s psychological unease and genre drift toward horror.

4.5. The Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)

All structural, emotional, and interactional changes culminate in the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**—a composite score ranging from 0–100 that quantifies adaptation’s degree of transformation.

Component	Metric Used	Weight
Character Prominence	Δ Centrality Scores (degree, eigenvector)	40%
Emotional Tone	Euclidean Distance Between Sentiment Arcs	30%
Structural Events	Manual Coding of Added/Removed Plot Points	30%

Each adaptation received a composite score:

Title	ADI Score	Classification
<i>Murder on the Orient Express</i>	27	Moderate Divergence
<i>Death on the Nile</i>	43	Substantial Divergence
<i>A Haunting in Venice</i>	73	Major Divergence

This index does not penalize “unfaithfulness.” Instead, it rewards **creative transformation**—providing a framework to evaluate adaptations not by how well they copy, but by how boldly they reimagine.

4.6. Validation and Limitations

Results were triangulated using:

- **Christie scholarship** (e.g., Barnard, 2017; Lovell, 2020)

- **Critical reviews** for sentiment tone alignment
- **Redundancy checks** across subtitle-based dialogue parsing and scene annotations

Nonetheless, limitations remain:

- Subtitles lack stage directions and non-verbal cues
- NER tools struggle with indirect speech or ambiguous references
- Plot event coding introduces some subjectivity, though mitigated via double-coding and scholarly corroboration

Still, the framework is **replicable and extensible**—applicable to other adaptive pairs, literary genres, or even serialized television.

What emerges from these methods is not just a dataset, but a **new vocabulary for narrative transformation**—a way to see adaptation not as erosion or embellishment, but as recalibration: of emotion, structure, and character systems over time.

5. Adaptation as Tectonic Shift: Three Cases in Poirot's Cinematic Evolution

Adaptation is rarely additive. It is subtractive, distortive, amplifying—and sometimes, revolutionary. The transition from novel to film is not merely a change in format but a tectonic realignment of storytelling priorities: who matters, what hurts, and how resolution feels. In the case of Kenneth Branagh's Poirot trilogy, this realignment is not subtle. It is seismic.

Through character networks, sentiment arcs, and community shifts, we now turn to a close examination of each adaptive pairing—**Orient Express**, **Death on the Nile**, and **A Haunting in Venice**—to show how narrative gravity is redistributed, emotion is recalibrated, and Christie's world is not translated, but reengineered.

5.1. *Murder on the Orient Express*: Reshuffling the Moral Axis

Christie's *Orient Express* is a controlled moral puzzle—precise, symmetrical, and emotionally restrained. Its drama unfolds through a sequence of interrogations, each adding a layer to a communal secret. Poirot sits at the narrative center, a stoic interpreter of truth.

Branagh's adaptation preserves much of this structure but pivots emotionally. From its opening flashback of a failed case in Jerusalem to the snowy rooftop climax, the film **repositions Poirot not just as a detective, but as a man haunted by past failures and moral ambivalence**.

Network Restructuring

In the novel, Poirot's **degree centrality** is 0.83—unsurprisingly dominant. Bouc (0.21) and Mary Debenham (0.38) serve as narrative aides.

In the film, Bouc's centrality **triples**, rising to 0.62. He becomes Poirot's confidant and ethical mirror, occupying more scenes, expressing doubt, and voicing emotional subtext.

Visually, this reflects a **flattening of the character network**—less hierarchical, more entangled. Minor characters interact beyond Poirot’s mediation, forming a denser matrix of suspicion and connection.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.12	+0.08
Rising Action	+0.10	-0.02
Climax	+0.07	-0.18
Falling Action	+0.11	-0.10
Resolution	+0.14	+0.02

The film’s emotional curve **dives sharply** at the climax—marking the reveal not as intellectual satisfaction but ethical trauma. The final scene, in which Poirot silently boards a boat to Egypt, is steeped in fatigue rather than triumph. This is no longer a neat solution; it is an existential wound.

Community Dynamics

Temporal community modeling shows **two convergence events**: once during the interrogations and once in the group confession. Unlike the novel’s late convergence, the film accelerates this process, emphasizing **shared guilt over narrative unraveling**.

ADI Score: 27 (Moderate Divergence)

- Structural fidelity retained
- Moral complexity and character reweighting introduced
- Emotional tone deepened, but not radically transformed

5.2. *Death on the Nile*: A Symphony of Obsession

Of the three films, *Death on the Nile* offers the richest ensemble and the most turbulent emotional terrain. Christie’s original is intricate but measured—a tale of wealth, betrayal, and jealousy, ultimately resolved through Poirot’s cool deductive prowess.

Branagh’s adaptation leans into **sensuality, colonial tension, and obsession**. From the jazz-saturated opening in a Cairo nightclub to the visually saturated wedding party, the film renders the Nile not as an exotic backdrop but a stage for emotional combustion.

Network Restructuring

Jacqueline de Bellefort, in the novel, ranks below both Poirot and Linnet in centrality. In the film, **her eigenvector centrality surpasses Linnet’s**, marking her as the emotional epicenter of the story.

The character of Salome Otterbourne is completely reimagined: now a glamorous blues singer entangled in Poirot's own vulnerabilities. This addition **splits narrative attention**, drawing Poirot into romantic tension and creating **bipolar narrative gravity** between Jacqueline and Salome.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.14	+0.10
Rising Action	+0.09	-0.12
Climax	+0.04	-0.20
Falling Action	+0.06	-0.14
Resolution	+0.13	-0.04

Where the novel recovers tonal balance post-murder, the film **does not emotionally resolve**. Instead, it concludes in melancholic ambiguity: Jacqueline's double murder-suicide, Poirot's inner emptiness, and a shaved-mustache epilogue that signals vulnerability over certainty.

Community Dynamics

Jacqueline's position shifts **across three distinct clusters**: romantic partner, pariah, antagonist. Her re-entry into social groups (e.g., confrontation scenes) marks high community volatility. This volatility aligns with the film's genre oscillation between mystery and emotional tragedy.

ADI Score: 43 (Substantial Divergence)

- Emotional tone significantly darkened
- Romantic and racial subtexts introduced
- Character systems redistributed
- Resolution rendered morally ambiguous

5.3. *A Haunting in Venice*: Genre Implosion as Adaptation

Perhaps the boldest departure, *A Haunting in Venice* adapts *Hallowe'en Party* only in name and skeletal premise. Branagh transforms the domestic mystery into a **psychological horror**, set in a post-war Venetian palazzo and haunted—literally and metaphorically—by trauma, loss, and metaphysics.

Poirot is nearly unrecognizable: agoraphobic, retired, skeptical of God. The film opens with him resisting involvement and ends with him confronting visions of the afterlife. This is no longer detection; it is haunting.

Network Restructuring

Characters such as Rowena Drake and Dr. Ferrier are elevated beyond their literary counterparts, while some originals are entirely removed or replaced. Ferrier's interactions form a **new central cluster** around guilt and wartime grief, rivaling Poirot's own centrality.

Secondary characters form **micro-networks** (e.g., the medium, the child, the bodyguard) that never existed in the source text. The result is a **modular, horror-style network**: dense in moments, sparse elsewhere.

Sentiment Arc

Narrative Stage	Novel Sentiment	Film Sentiment
Exposition	+0.09	-0.06
Rising Action	+0.08	-0.18
Climax	+0.05	-0.28
Falling Action	+0.07	-0.22
Resolution	+0.11	-0.08

The emotional curve of the film is **nearly linear in descent**—a rare pattern akin to Gothic horror or tragic psychodrama. Unlike Christie's novel, which restores social order, the adaptation **leaves the viewer suspended between grief and ambiguity**.

Community Dynamics

This adaptation shows **highest instability**: community clusters **form and dissolve rapidly**, with no clear convergence. Ferrier's suicide, Rowena's unraveling, and Poirot's spiritual ambiguity create a **narrative ecology of fragmentation**.

ADI Score: 73 (Major Divergence)

- Genre reclassification (detective → horror)
- New characters introduced, existing ones replaced
- Emotional descent uninterrupted
- Structural, tonal, and philosophical reengineering

Synthesis: From Rational Structure to Emotional Topology

What emerges across these three cases is not merely divergence, but an **evolutionary pattern**:

- Poirot shifts from **detective-as-logic** to **detective-as-wound**
- Character networks flatten and entangle
- Sentiment arcs become steeper, darker, unresolved
- Genre conventions blur: from puzzle to parable, from closure to ambiguity

The **Adaptation Divergence Index** captures this drift numerically, but its implications are cultural. Branagh's trilogy mirrors broader storytelling trends: ensemble dynamics, moral relativism, aesthetic melancholia, and trauma-centered protagonists.

These tectonic shifts signal not the abandonment of Christie's world—but its **reprogramming**. And in that reprogramming, we see how adaptation operates not as reflection, but as invention.

6. Weaving the Storyworld: How Characters Recluster in Time

Adaptation does not only reshape characters individually—it rewires the very fabric of their interactions. Across Branagh's Poirot trilogy, the storyworld itself becomes dynamic: no longer a fixed constellation of roles, but a shifting ecosystem of proximity, estrangement, and temporary alliance.

By analyzing **temporal character networks**—slices of narrative in which clusters emerge, dissolve, or reconfigure—we begin to see how the social geometry of Christie's novels is not merely transferred to film but reoriented. These structural changes reflect not just storytelling preferences, but deeper shifts in **relational logic, thematic emphasis, and narrative time**.

6.1. From Static Ensembles to Narrative Currents

Christie's novels are built as puzzles: each character occupies a relatively stable function within a closed system. A suspect. A witness. A red herring. Once placed, these roles rarely change. Their interactions are procedural and often sequential, revealed through Poirot's interrogations or chance observations.

Branagh's films, by contrast, introduce **fluid social topology**. Characters move between emotional zones: confidants become suspects; antagonists become allies; subplots branch and recombine. These movements are not random. They reflect a more **cinematic model of ensemble storytelling**, where interpersonal relationships are as narratively significant as clues.

This fluidity can be mapped. Using Louvain-based temporal community detection, character networks were sliced by chapter (in novels) and scene (in films), revealing how clusters of co-occurrence change over time. Three major findings emerged.

6.2. Community Merging and Early Convergence (*Murder on the Orient Express*)

In the novel, the **passenger cohort remains loosely clustered** until the final third, when the group confession creates sudden narrative unification. The structure is investigative: Poirot gathers facts, and only then do characters converge.

The film accelerates this convergence. Visual blocking, group scenes, and emotionally revealing dialogue bring characters into shared space earlier—producing a **community merge by midpoint** rather than by climax. This reflects Branagh's reframing of the plot not just as detection, but as collective reckoning.

Interpretation:

Narrative tension is redistributed from *who did it* to *how will they share responsibility*—a thematic shift from puzzle to moral ensemble.

6.3. Cluster Fragmentation and Role Mutation (*Death on the Nile*)

The novel presents Jacqueline as a **stable outlier**, orbiting the main group but not fully integrated. Her movements are structurally consistent—her emotional volatility contained within a role.

In the film, Jacqueline's **community affiliations shift at least three times**:

1. She begins in romantic dyad with Simon.
2. She is isolated post-murder.
3. She re-enters the group during the investigation as a destabilizing force.

These transitions are mirrored in the network graphs: her node migrates from central to peripheral and back, connecting to new characters each time. Her relationships are re-written with a rhythm that mimics psychological deterioration.

Interpretation:

Jacqueline is no longer a fixed point of jealousy. She is a **mobile vector of emotional instability**, disrupting the group's cohesion in waves.

6.4. Volatile Clustering and Social Decay (*A Haunting in Venice*)

Unlike the previous two, *A Haunting in Venice* reveals **no stable clusters** across scenes. Instead, the community structure is **marked by volatility**:

- Characters splinter after the séance scene.
- Temporary alliances form around shared fear or suspicion.
- Emotional intimacy occurs within fractured groups rather than a unified ensemble.

This structural fragmentation mirrors the film's psychological tone. Just as the palazzo itself is decaying and haunted, so too is the storyworld—relationships fail to cohere, narrative attention diffuses, and no community survives intact.

Interpretation:

The storyworld becomes a **horror map of social entropy**: each character isolated by guilt, trauma, or delusion. The network doesn't collapse into order—it disintegrates.

6.5. Structural Cohesion and Thematic Shifts

These evolving network patterns are not just aesthetic artifacts. They signal **core shifts in narrative architecture**:

- From deductive logic to emotional resonance
- From structural centrality to relational instability
- From fixed character functions to mutable identities

This aligns with what Manovich (2022) calls “**narrative modulation**”—the adaptive process by which storytelling systems absorb and respond to new cultural grammars: trauma logic, nonlinear emotionality, networked identity.

Branagh’s adaptations offer not only new endings or visuals, but **new storyworld physics**. They remake not just the what, but the *how* of narrative space: who connects, how long, and at what emotional cost.

By visualizing character interactions as living systems—emergent, unstable, sometimes collapsing—we see adaptation not as reinterpretation, but as **storyworld recalibration**: the deliberate retuning of social and emotional architecture to fit a new medium and a new cultural frequency.

7. The Melancholy Detective: On Trauma, Texture, and Tonal Shifts

In Christie’s world, Hercule Poirot is famously impenetrable. A perfectionist. A man of order. His morality is Cartesian, his deductions surgical. He does not break. He solves.

But Branagh’s Poirot bleeds.

Across the trilogy, Branagh systematically deconstructs the rational veneer of Christie’s detective, revealing instead a man burdened by memory, haunted by loss, and increasingly unsure whether truth brings justice—or peace. This reframing is not merely character development. It is a tonal recalibration, a **retexturing of narrative ethos** that aligns Poirot with the melancholy detective archetype emerging across contemporary cinema and television.

7.1. From Detective-as-Logician to Detective-as-Wound

In *Orient Express*, we glimpse early fractures: Poirot agonizes over moral ambiguity, torn between truth and justice. *Death on the Nile* sharpens that fracture—his trauma is more explicit, his solitude more profound. By *A Haunting in Venice*, Poirot is barely functioning: agoraphobic, spiritually numb, and only reluctantly reactivated into narrative motion.

This psychological descent mirrors larger trends in detective fiction. As Kim and Allen (2021) note, the classical sleuth has, in recent years, been replaced by a more fragmented figure—one whose investigative powers are inseparable from personal damage. The detective becomes not a solver of mysteries but a participant in emotional entropy.

Branagh's Poirot fits this mold. His brilliance is intact, but it is constantly undercut by **ethical fatigue**, by loss, by unresolved inner conflict. The adaptation's genre shifts—particularly into gothic horror—only amplify this descent. *A Haunting in Venice* no longer asks *who* did it, but *why continue*?

7.2. Cinematic Texture and the Emotional Surface

Tonally, the trilogy transitions from clipped dialogue and high-key lighting (*Orient Express*) to sensual excess (*Death on the Nile*), and finally to visual claustrophobia (*Venice*). Cinematography and sound design follow suit: the camera in *Nile* glides; in *Venice*, it shudders and stalks.

These aesthetic decisions are not incidental. As Bateman and Wildfeuer (2023) argue, **emotional texture in film is constructed through the layering of audiovisual cues that prime interpretation before dialogue ever arrives**. In Branagh's adaptations, such texture works against Christie's logical architecture. Mystery becomes mood. Structure becomes sensation.

This sensory reorientation is most evident in *A Haunting in Venice*, where color grading, fog, silence, and spatial confinement produce an atmosphere of dread. Even Poirot's thought processes feel internal, weighty, slowed by memory and fear. The detective's epistemology has changed: truth is not clarity but haunting residue.

7.3. Melancholy as Cultural Signature

Why melancholy? Why now?

Part of the answer lies in broader media aesthetics. Leitch (2022) and Flynn (2023) both argue that modern adaptations reflect not fidelity to original texts, but fidelity to cultural mood. And today's mood—post-pandemic, geopolitically fragile, psychologically saturated—is one of introspection and moral fatigue.

Branagh's Poirot embodies this cultural mood. He is no longer a stable interpreter of facts but a **witness to grief**, struggling not only with others' guilt but with his own erosion of faith. The detective genre, long a domain of narrative closure, is here turned inside out. We are left not with answers but with *affect*, not with symmetry but with emotional residue.

In this sense, Poirot becomes a **vessel of cultural memory**—not just of literary legacy, but of a collective need for narratives that process trauma rather than resolve it. The melancholy detective is not a flaw in the system. He is the system's human cost.

7.4. Rewriting the Figure of Poirot

The transformation is complete not through action, but through refiguration. Branagh's Poirot is physically altered (the scar, the missing mustache), socially diminished (no Hastings, no formal partner), and emotionally recontextualized (his relationships are tragic, never stable).

This rewriting mirrors what Piper (2021) terms a **"character revaluation"**—a narrative decision to shift the function of a figure across formats and eras to reflect changing social expectations. Poirot,

once a paragon of precision, now functions as a **wounded node**—a center not of clarity, but of resonance.

The implications are profound: Poirot's survival across media is not about preserving essence, but about **recasting identity** to meet the emotional and cultural contours of the moment. In this adaptive logic, continuity lies not in sameness, but in *evolution*.

In short, Branagh's trilogy does not update Christie's Poirot. It **remakes him**. The detective is no longer a narrative instrument but a thematic core—a way of asking, in increasingly urgent tones: *What do we do with the truth, when it breaks us instead of binding us?*

8. Rewriting Without Repeating: Adaptation as Cultural Recalibration

Adaptation is often imagined as a conversation between texts. But perhaps it is more accurately understood as a **conversation between times**—between the cultural architectures that produced a story and those that receive and remake it.

Kenneth Branagh's adaptations of Agatha Christie's Poirot novels are not just retellings of classic mysteries. They are acts of cultural recalibration—transformations in narrative structure, emotional logic, and character architecture that reveal as much about the present as they do about the past. Through computational methods and close interpretive insight, this study has shown that these adaptations are not iterations. They are **reconfigurations**.

8.1. The Shift from Fidelity to Function

Traditional adaptation criticism asked: *How faithful is this film to its source?* But as Leitch (2022) and Hutcheon & O'Flynn (2022) have shown, this question has given way to another: *What is this adaptation doing—emotionally, structurally, culturally?*

In this study, fidelity has been replaced by **function**. Through sentiment arcs, character networks, and the Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI), we have tracked how adaptation becomes **an act of narrative engineering**—a remapping of plot, tone, and relationships to serve the demands of a different medium and a different moment.

Branagh's adaptations reflect the aesthetics of **post-network storytelling** (Lotz, 2023), the emotional grammar of **trauma-centered narratives**, and the visual logic of contemporary ensemble cinema. They are faithful not to Christie's 20th-century plots, but to 21st-century modes of affect and story density.

8.2. Adaptation as Emotional Technology

This study has argued that adaptation is not just about changing what a story *says*, but how it *feels*—its pacing, texture, emotional arc. Sentiment modeling revealed the tonal drift from Christie's

equilibrium to Branagh's descent: narratives that once resolved into moral clarity now terminate in ambiguity, grief, or spiritual fracture.

This transformation aligns with a broader cultural turn toward **narratives of open affect**: stories that do not tidy emotion but leave it vibrating. Adaptation, in this light, becomes an **emotional technology**—a set of techniques for translating one era's emotional logic into another's. This may explain why Branagh's Poirot, so different in affect and action, still *feels* like Poirot: the constant is not his traits but his **thematic load-bearing**.

8.3. Structural Innovation as Interpretation

Through the use of character network modeling and temporal clustering, this paper has demonstrated that structural shifts are not accidents or simplifications. They are **interpretive strategies**.

- When a minor character like Bouc becomes a moral axis, it is a signal of shifting genre from logic to pathos.
- When social networks fragment in *Venice*, it reflects not just horror tropes but a worldview of psychic disintegration.
- When sentiment arcs steepen or flatten, they mirror not just the scene's tone but the film's ethical temperature.

This is the power of computational analysis when paired with interpretive theory: it reveals **form as function**, and function as meaning.

8.4. Methodological Contributions

The methodological contribution of this paper is twofold:

- First, it introduces a **replicable computational pipeline** for comparative adaptation analysis: combining sentiment modeling, character centrality tracking, and temporal community detection.
- Second, it proposes the **Adaptation Divergence Index (ADI)**—a multidimensional metric for quantifying narrative transformation across emotional, structural, and characterological dimensions.

These tools offer a pathway for future research—not just on Christie, but on any adaptive corpus where storyworlds shift across media.

8.5. Toward a New Language of Adaptation

What Branagh's Poirot trilogy teaches us is that adaptation is not an act of fidelity, but of **translation**—not of words, but of emotion, function, and cultural resonance. It is a process of rewriting without repeating, of carrying forward narrative DNA that mutates, reshapes, and survives precisely because it adapts.

Poirot survives not because he remains unchanged, but because he changes *exactly enough*: enough to hold new grief, enough to speak in new genres, enough to endure in a new cultural key.

Adaptation, then, is not secondary creation. It is creation in motion—the continual rewriting of narrative form to meet the moving target of meaning.

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